

Image 1.3: Map of the boundary of Jammu and Kashmir as depicted by the Treaty of Chushul, 1842

Source: Archives of AIM Television Pvt. Ltd.

The death of Maharaja Ranjit Singh in 1839 plunged the Sikh Empire into instability. This coincided with the untimely deaths of Gulab Singh's two brothers, Dhyan and Suchet Singh, and that of his nephew Hira Singh, who were all prominent functionaries in the Sikh Empire. This paved the way for Gulab Singh to consolidate his position of power within the declining empire. These deaths were concurrent to the demise of all Maharaja Ranjit Singh's sons and grandsons, save his youngest son Duleep Singh. Gulab Singh struck a deep friendship with Col. Henry Lawrence of the East India Company in 1842 and decided to gradually wean himself away from the Sikh Empire.[13]

A master of politics, Gulab Singh's secret alliance with the British led him to refuse the command of the Sikh army. As a result, he was able to stay away from the First Anglo-Sikh War of 1845–46. Gulab Singh's decision was a major tactical and strategic boost for the East India